

The Montgomery Bus Boycott, 1955–56

Part A: Source Investigation

SOURCE A

Letter from the Women's Political Council to Mayor W. A. Gayle

Jo Ann Robinson, president of the Women's Political Council (WPC) — an organization of Black professional women, mostly educators — wrote this letter on 21 May 1954, four days after the Brown v. Board of Education ruling. It followed an earlier, unsuccessful meeting with city officials in March 1954.

“The Women's Political Council is very grateful to you and the City Commissioners for the hearing you allowed our representative during the month of March, 1954... There were several things the Council asked for: A city law that would make it possible for Negroes to sit from back toward front, and whites from front toward back until all the seats are taken; that Negroes not be asked or forced to pay fare at front and go to the rear of the bus to enter; that busses stop at every corner in residential sections occupied by Negroes as they do in communities where whites reside.

Mayor Gayle, three-fourths of the riders of these public conveyances are Negroes. If Negroes did not patronize them, they could not possibly operate. More and more of our people are already arranging with neighbors and friends to ride to keep from being insulted and humiliated by bus drivers. There has been talk from twenty-five or more local organizations of planning a city-wide boycott of busses. We, sir, do not feel that forceful measures are necessary in bargaining for a convenience which is right for all bus passengers...

Please consider this plea, and if possible, act favorably upon it, for even now plans are being made to ride less, or not at all, on our busses. We do not want this.”

SOURCE B

Handbill distributed across Black Montgomery, overnight, 1–2 December 1955

Drafted by Jo Ann Robinson within hours of Rosa Parks' arrest, mimeographed at Alabama State College, and distributed door-to-door, at schools, and at businesses by Robinson and student volunteers before dawn. Reverends King and Abernathy revised and redistributed it over the following days.

“Another Negro woman has been arrested and thrown in jail because she refused to get up out of her seat on the bus for a white person to sit down. It is the second time since the Claudette Colvin case that a Negro woman has been arrested for the same thing. This has to be stopped. Negroes have rights, too, for if Negroes did not ride the buses, they could not operate. Three-fourths of the riders are Negroes, yet we are arrested, or have to stand over empty seats. If we do not do something to stop these arrests, they will continue. The next time it may be you, or your daughter, or mother.

This woman's case will come up on Monday. We are, therefore, asking every Negro to stay off the buses Monday in protest of the arrest and trial... But please, children and grown-ups, don't ride the bus at all on Monday. Please stay off of all buses Monday.”

SOURCE C

Letter from Rev. Robert Graetz to Time Magazine

Graetz was a white Lutheran minister leading a Black congregation in Montgomery and a member of the MIA's executive board; his home was later bombed twice. He wrote privately to a national news editor on 22 December 1955, three weeks into the boycott, copying Dr. King and the MIA's lawyer.

“There is a story in the making here in Montgomery, Alabama, that may be just as explosive as the Till case... I am referring to the protest which the Negroes (and many whites) of Montgomery are making against the local bus company... What you may not know is that only part of the story is actually reaching the public through the normal channels of communication. The local newspapers have consistently printed one-sided stories about the developments in this protest... all of the 'law-enforcement' agencies in the city and county have been doing everything possible to break the back of our campaign... If you want a good look at the way a one-race press and a one-race police force band together to discredit fifty thousand people who are tired of being treated like animals on the city busses... I urge you to send a reporter to Montgomery as soon as possible.”

SOURCE D

David J. Garrow, historian, “The Origins of the Montgomery Bus Boycott”

Garrow, a political scientist, drew on personal interviews with surviving participants (Robinson, Nixon, Gray, and others) for this 1985 scholarly article, written thirty years after the boycott.

“‘We had planned the protest long before Mrs. Parks was arrested,’ Mrs. Robinson later emphasized. ‘There had been so many things that happened that the black women had been embarrassed over, and they were ready to explode.’ They knew immediately that ‘Mrs. Parks had the caliber of character we needed to get the city to rally behind us.’

The WPC’s post-haste distribution of the announcements, Robinson and Nixon knew, ought to short-circuit any arguments that now was not a good time for a boycott, even before they could be voiced. As Fred Gray later emphasized, ‘the ministers didn’t know anything about those leaflets until they appeared.’

[The Women’s Political Council, historian J. Mills Thornton has written, was] ‘the most militant and uncompromising organ of the black community’ in pre-1956 Montgomery.”

Questions

1(a). According to Source A, what specific changes did the Women's Political Council request from the city, and on what grounds did Robinson argue the city should grant them? **[3 marks]**

1(b). According to Source D, why did the timing and method of the leaflet's distribution matter to the boycott's success? **[2 marks]**

2. Compare and contrast what Sources B and C reveal about the methods used to build support for the boycott. **[6 marks]**

Aim for a genuine paragraph of comparison AND a genuine paragraph of contrast — don't just describe the two sources one after another. Consider: audience, tone, and what each author assumed their reader already believed.

3. With reference to their origin, purpose, and content, assess the value and limitations of Source A and Source C for a historian studying how the boycott built and sustained support. **[6 marks]**

Push past "it's useful because it's a primary source" — that alone earns almost no credit. What can each source tell you precisely because of who wrote it and why? What can it NOT tell you for the same reason?

4. Using the sources and your own knowledge, evaluate the view that the success of the Montgomery Bus Boycott is best explained by long-term grassroots organizing rather than the actions of individual leaders. **[9 marks]**

This question rewards a clear line of argument, not a list. Decide your answer before you write the first sentence. You must use at least three of the four sources AND bring in outside knowledge (e.g. Claudette Colvin, the MIA's formation, Browder v. Gayle) that goes beyond what's printed here.
